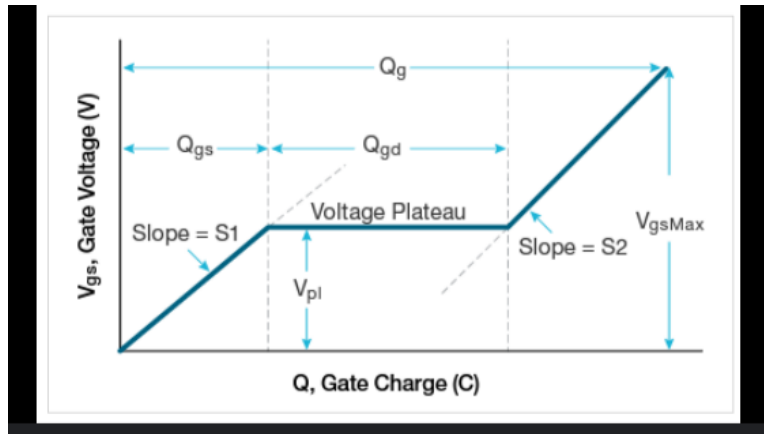




Understanding Plateau Voltage in Power MOSFETs and Its Importance in Power Electronics



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June 26, 2025

Introduction

Power MOSFETs (Metal-Oxide-Semiconductor Field-Effect Transistors) are fundamental components in power electronics due to their fast switching and high efficiency. In power converters, motor drivers, and inverters, understanding the switching behavior of the MOSFET is critical. One important part of this behavior is the plateau voltage, often referred to as the Miller plateau. Though it appears as a flat region on the gate voltage waveform, its impact on performance, switching speed, and losses is significant.

1. What is Plateau Voltage?

The plateau voltage is the flat region observed in the gate voltage waveform when the MOSFET transitions from off to on (or vice versa). This occurs when the gate voltage stops rising momentarily, even though current is still flowing into the gate.

This behavior is caused by the Miller effect, which is due to the interaction between the gate and drain terminals through the gate-drain capacitance (often denoted as C_{gd}). As the drain voltage changes rapidly during switching, the gate current is diverted to charge or discharge this capacitance, preventing the gate voltage from rising or falling during that time.

2. Gate Charging Stages

When turning the MOSFET on, the gate charging process happens in three stages:

Turn-On Process:

- Initial rise: Gate voltage increases rapidly, charging the gate-source capacitance (C_{gs}), until it reaches the threshold voltage (V_{th}).
- Plateau region: The gate voltage stops rising and stays nearly constant at the plateau voltage, while the drain voltage falls and the current increases.
- Final rise: After the drain voltage settles, the gate voltage resumes rising until it reaches the full drive voltage (e.g., 10 V to 15 V).

Turn-Off Process:

- Gate voltage drops to the plateau voltage.
- Plateau region: Gate voltage remains flat while the drain voltage rises.
- Finally, the gate voltage drops below the threshold, and the MOSFET turns off completely.

3. Formula for Plateau Voltage

Plateau voltage can be approximately calculated using the following formula:

$$V_{\text{plateau}} \approx V_{th} + (I_D / g_m)$$

Where:

- V_{plateau} is the plateau voltage
- V_{th} is the threshold voltage of the MOSFET
- I_D is the drain current during switching
- g_m is the transconductance of the MOSFET

This equation shows that the plateau voltage increases with higher load current. Designers must take this into account, especially when driving MOSFETs under different load conditions.

4. Why is Plateau Voltage Important?

a. Gate Driver Requirements

- During the plateau, the gate driver must supply or sink significant current to charge or discharge C_{gd} .
- The gate driver needs enough drive strength (current capability) to complete this transition quickly and avoid slow switching.

b. Switching Losses

- During the plateau period, both drain voltage and drain current are present simultaneously, resulting in high switching losses.
- A longer plateau duration increases energy loss during switching.
- Fast and efficient gate drivers help reduce the duration of this period and improve overall efficiency.

c. dv/dt Control and EMI

During the plateau, the drain voltage changes rapidly (high dv/dt).

High dv/dt can lead to:

- Unwanted gate voltage changes in nearby transistors (causing false turn-on)
- Electromagnetic interference (EMI)
- Increased voltage stress on components
- Controlling the duration of the plateau helps manage these effects.

d. Gate Resistor Selection

- The gate resistor directly influences the charging and discharging current of the gate.
- A smaller gate resistor reduces the plateau duration, improving efficiency but potentially increasing EMI.
- A larger resistor increases switching time and reduces dv/dt , but increases losses.

Choosing the right gate resistor is a trade-off between switching speed and electromagnetic compatibility.

5. Practical Design Example

Let's consider the following values for a power MOSFET:

- Threshold voltage, $V_{th} = 2.5 \text{ V}$
- Drain current, $I_D = 15 \text{ A}$
- Transconductance, $g_m = 10 \text{ S}$

Using the formula:

$$V_{\text{plateau}} = 2.5 + (15 / 10) = 2.5 + 1.5 = 4.0 \text{ V}$$

So the gate voltage will pause around 4.0 V during switching, and the gate driver must be able to maintain this voltage while supplying current to C_{gd} .

6. How to Minimize Plateau Effects

To improve performance and reduce the adverse effects of the plateau voltage, you can:

- Use high-speed gate drivers with low output impedance.
- Optimize the gate resistance to balance switching speed and EMI.
- Choose MOSFETs with lower gate-drain capacitance (C_{gd}) and higher transconductance (g_m).
- Use gate drivers with built-in Miller clamp features to prevent false turn-on during turn-off.
- Keep gate loop inductance low by using short and wide PCB traces.

7. Observing Plateau Voltage

You can observe the plateau voltage on an oscilloscope by probing the gate and drain waveforms:

- The gate voltage will show a flat section (the plateau) during switching.
- The duration of this plateau gives insight into the quality of gate drive and potential switching losses.
- Analyzing this helps you optimize your power electronics system for better thermal performance and efficiency.

Conclusion

The plateau voltage in power MOSFETs plays a critical role in determining switching speed, energy loss, and EMI behavior. Understanding this parameter helps engineers:

- Select proper gate drivers
- Tune gate resistors
- Minimize switching losses
- Enhance system reliability

In any power electronics design — whether it's a DC-DC converter, motor drive, or inverter — careful consideration of the plateau voltage and gate charge dynamics is essential for robust and efficient performance.

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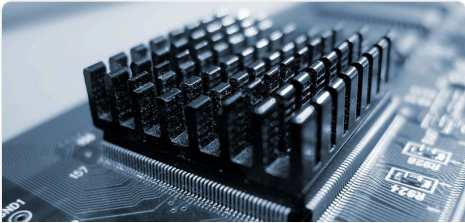




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